

HEDGEHOGS AND OTHER INSECTIVORES



THE ORDER INSECTIVORA, which means insect-eating, contains more than 370 species, including hedgehogs, moles, shrews, and tenrecs. Most of these mammals, especially the shrews, are highly active and have to eat almost constantly to sustain themselves. They have poor eyesight, but a good sense of smell. They rely on smell to find their prey of worms and snails as well as insects. Insectivores have sharp teeth for preying on invertebrates. The hedgehogs and some tenrecs are protected from predators by spines.

The long snout bears many highly sensitive whiskers which the hedgehog uses to find its way around and also to locate food.

A female hedgehog usually has two litters of young each year.



Ordinary fur grows on the chest and belly.

Hedgehogs

Like most insectivores, hedgehogs are nocturnal, solitary animals that associate only to mate. Each adult animal needs its own territory in order to find enough to eat. Not all hedgehogs are spiny, but the European and desert hedgehogs have a thick covering of spines on the top of the head and body to protect them against predators such as foxes.

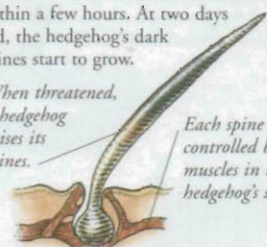
European hedgehogs build up a layer of fat during the summer to sustain them during the winter when they hibernate.

Young hedgehogs accompany their mother to find food.

Hedgehog spines

A European hedgehog has about 5,000 spines. These are hairs modified into sharp, stiff tubes. Hedgehogs are born with their first coat of pale spines flat under the skin, but these come through within a few hours. At two days old, the hedgehog's dark spines start to grow.

When threatened, a hedgehog raises its spines.



Each spine is controlled by muscles in the hedgehog's skin.



Spines normally lie flat over the hedgehog's body.

For extra protection, a hedgehog can roll into a prickly ball.



Young hedgehogs stay with their mother until they are about seven weeks old.

Moles

Moles live underground in a system of tunnels that they dig through the soil. They are well adapted for this existence, having a compact body, short legs, tiny eyes, and no protruding ears. They are active day and night, looking for food such as worms, insect larvae, and beetles.

Fur lies in no particular direction, so that the mole can push backward or forward through its tunnels.



Strong claws for loosening the soil.

Molehills

Mounds of soil, often called molehills, are the result of a mole's tunnelling activities. The mole pushes loose soil to the surface up short vertical tunnels.



A nest under the mound

Mole feet

The front paws are broad with large claws, and do the digging. The hind feet are narrower with sharp claws, and are used to push soil to the surface.



Shrews

These small mammals have a long snout and short legs. They are highly active and need a constant supply of food to keep them alive. Shrews are extremely aggressive and will attack one another if they meet. Many predators avoid shrews because of a foul-smelling secretion that they can produce from scent glands.

Shrews eat up to 130 per cent of their body weight every day.



Tenrecs

The 30 species of tenrec live only on the island of Madagascar. Some swim, some climb, and others live underground. Some have spines, others look more like shrews. They have many young. The common tenrec may have 34 in one litter.



EUROPEAN HEDGEHOG

SCIENTIFIC NAME *Erinaceus europaeus*

ORDER Insectivora

FAMILY Erinaceidae

DISTRIBUTION Europe, east into Russia. Introduced to New Zealand

HABITAT Farmland, suburbs, woodland, and mountains

DIET Beetles, worms, caterpillars, other invertebrates, small mammals, and carrion

SIZE Length: 25 cm (10 in)

LIFESPAN 4-7 years

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